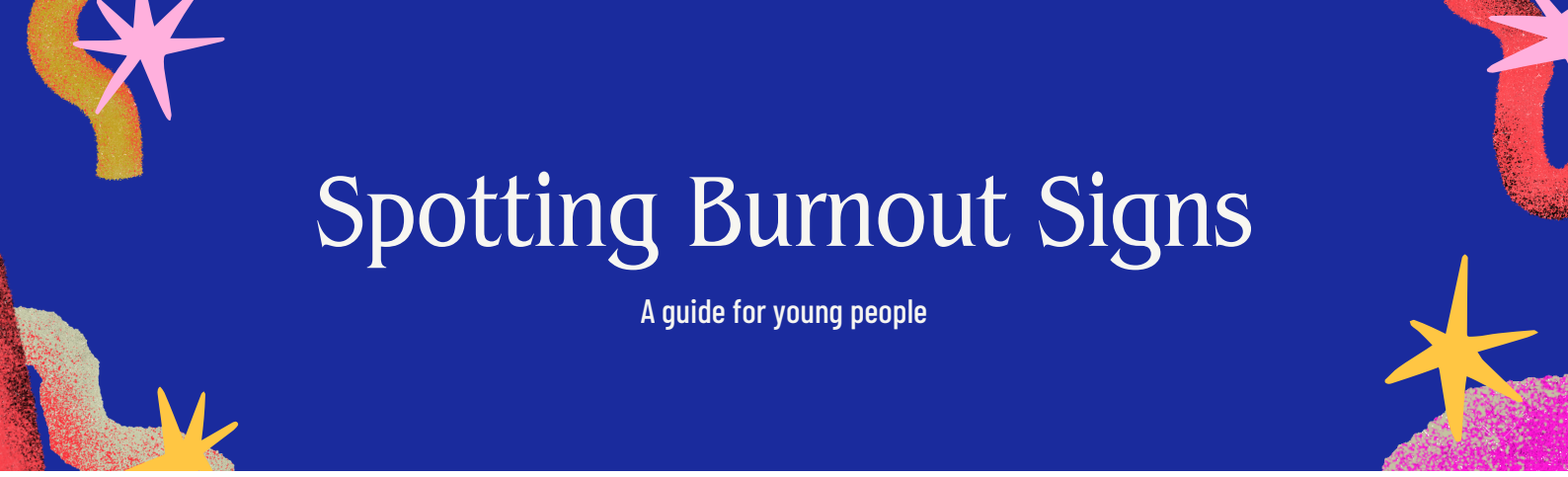




Spotting Burnout Signs

A guide for young people

What is Burnout?

Burnout is a state of emotional, physical, and mental exhaustion caused by excessive and prolonged stress. It happens when you feel overwhelmed, emotionally drained, and unable to meet constant demands. When you're experiencing burnout, you may lose interest and motivation in activities you once enjoyed.

For young people, burnout can creep up due to academic pressures, extracurricular activities, social expectations, and personal challenges. It's important to recognise that it's okay to feel this way, and that seeking help and making changes is a sign of strength.

Common Signs of Burnout

Emotional Signs

- **Feeling drained or exhausted:** Always feeling tired, even after sleeping.
- **Loss of motivation:** Struggling to start or complete tasks, even things you used to enjoy.
- **Increased irritability or frustration:** Snapping at others or feeling easily annoyed.
- **Feeling detached or cynical:** Losing interest in school, friends, or hobbies.
- **Feeling helpless or hopeless:** Believing things won't get better.

Physical Signs

- **Headaches or muscle pain:** Frequent and unexplained physical discomfort.
- **Changes in appetite or sleep patterns:** Eating more or less than usual, or having trouble sleeping or sleeping too much.
- **Lowered immunity:** Getting sick more often.
- **Fatigue:** Persistent tiredness that doesn't go away with rest.

Behavioral Signs

- **Procrastination:** Putting off tasks more than usual.
- **Withdrawing from responsibilities:** Avoiding schoolwork, chores, or social events.
- **Using coping substances:** Relying on things like alcohol or drugs to deal with stress.
- **Skipping school or activities:** Missing obligations more frequently.

Your Burnout Detective Activity

Let's explore your own experiences to help you become a burnout detective!

Instructions: Take some time to reflect on the past few weeks or months. Answer the following questions honestly. There are no right or wrong answers. This is just for you!

1. **Energy Levels:** On a scale of 1 to 5, how would you rate your energy levels most days? (1 = Always exhausted, 5 = Usually have plenty of energy)
2. **Motivation:** How motivated do you feel to do your schoolwork or extracurricular activities? (1 = Not at all motivated, 5 = Very motivated)
3. **Enjoyment:** How much joy are you getting from activities you usually like (e.g., hobbies, hanging out with friends)? (1 = No joy, 5 = Lots of joy)
4. **Irritability:** How easily do you get frustrated or annoyed with others? (1 = Rarely annoyed, 5 = Very easily annoyed)
5. **Sleep:** How well are you sleeping on most nights? (1 = Poorly, 5 = Very well)
6. **Physical Symptoms:** Have you noticed any new headaches, stomachaches, or muscle pains recently?
 - Yes
 - No

Reflection:

- Look at your answers. Are there any patterns or answers that stand out to you?
- Do any of your answers remind you of the signs of burnout we discussed earlier?
- What is one small thing you could do this week to help yourself feel a little better, even if it's just for a short while?

What to Do Next

Recognising the signs is the first step! If you're feeling signs of burnout, it's important to reach out. Talk to a trusted adult: a parent, guardian, teacher, school counselor, or another adult you feel comfortable with. They can help you find ways to manage your stress and make positive changes. Remember, taking care of yourself is essential.